Demystifying College

A Leadership Learning Intervention for the Peer Advising Program

Kristen Ekstrom

School Of Education, William & Mary

EPPL 619: Leadership and Change in Higher Education

Dr. Erica Wiborg

Leadership Learning Intervention:

A Workshop Series for the

Peer Advisor Program

Table of Contents

Introduction.....1

Student Group Description.....1

Problem of Practice.....2

Learning Outcomes.....2

Theoretical Framework.....3

Program Format & Justification.....5

Schedule & Timeline.....5

Pedagogical Approach & Justification.....6

Integration & Connection.....7

References.....8

Appendix: Sample Lesson Plans.....9

Demystifying College: The Peer Advising Program

- Peer support is a valuable resource during the transition into college, as students often turn to fellow undergraduates for guidance.
- However, being a knowledgeable peer does not automatically translate to being an effective peer educator. Students in peer education roles benefit from intentional training that develops their capacity to facilitate learning rather than simply share information.
- This intervention approaches peer advisor training as leadership development, grounding skill-building in theoretical frameworks that emphasize process-oriented leadership and adaptive facilitation.

Student Group Description

This leadership learning intervention is designed for undergraduate Peer Advisors at the College of William & Mary who support incoming first-year and transfer students, primarily during registration and early academic transition. Peer Advisors serve as guides to help new students navigate academic systems, institutional expectations, and advising processes. The program is intended to be administered by professional staff within the Advising Center as part of existing Peer Advisor training and onboarding.

Problem of Practice

Peer Advisors are expected to support incoming students in navigating complex academic systems. While institutional information is readily available, helping students interpret and apply that information effectively requires additional skills in facilitation and sense-making. This intervention addresses the need for Peer Advisors to move beyond information delivery toward supporting student understanding and ownership.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this program, Peer Advisors will be able to:

1. Distinguish between technical questions and adaptive challenges in advising conversations, and respond appropriately based on the type of student need
2. Translate institutional knowledge into accessible, student-centered guidance, tailoring explanations based on individual student needs and prior familiarity with academic systems
3. Facilitate student understanding of academic systems by prioritizing interpretation and sense-making alongside information-sharing
4. Identify and address hidden curriculum gaps by recognizing implicit academic expectations that may be unfamiliar to incoming students
5. Guide advising conversations toward clear, actionable next steps that transfer ownership and decision-making to the student

Theoretical Framework

This program is grounded in Adaptive Leadership. It also embodies the shift from stage 3 to stage 4 within Leadership Identity Development (LID).

☼ Adaptive Leadership ☼

Adaptive Leadership frames leadership as the ability to help others navigate complex challenges that do not have clear technical solutions. Central to this theory is the distinction between technical problems, which can be resolved through authoritative responses and existing knowledge, and adaptive challenges, which often require learning as both the problem and solution are unclear.

> In peer advising contexts, technical questions might include "What's the add/drop deadline?" while adaptive challenges involve situations like "I want to be pre-med, but I'm struggling in chemistry. What should I do?"

Adaptive Leadership theory can help Peer Advisors diagnose the type of support students need and respond appropriately. Technical questions require information delivery; adaptive challenges require facilitating student sense-making and learning. Adaptive work often involves uncertainty and necessitates letting go of existing assumptions. Peer advisors may initially struggle with this, as information delivery feels more straightforward and less risky.

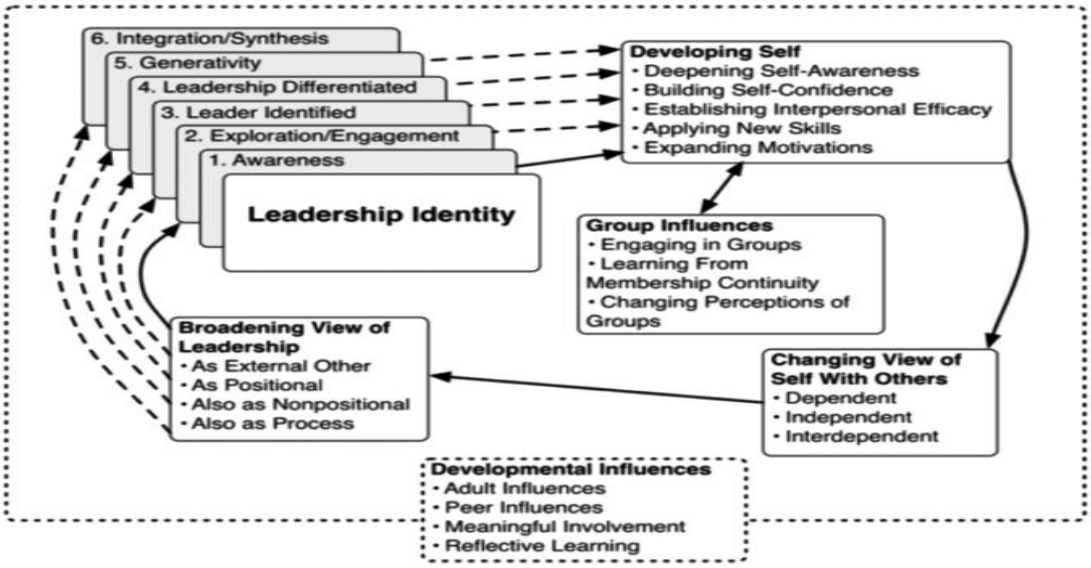
The theory also emphasizes a need to create holding environments: spaces where people can engage with difficult questions without becoming overwhelmed. This training program functions as a holding environment where peer advisors can practice diagnostic and facilitation skills, experience discomfort in ambiguous advising scenarios, and develop new approaches through structured reflection and peer feedback.

☼ Leadership Identity Development ☼

Leadership Identity Development (LID) conceptualizes leadership as a developmental process rather than a positional role. This intervention specifically supports the transition from Stage 3 (Leader Identified) to Stage 4 (Leadership Differentiated), a shift that redefines what it means to be a leader in a peer advising context.

In Stage 3, students operate within positional leadership roles, viewing leadership as something tied to formal positions and responsibilities. Peer advisors operating at Stage 3 see themselves as the ones with knowledge and answers: their role is to provide information and direct students toward solutions.	Stage 4 represents a fundamental shift in understanding leadership as a process rather than a person. It involves movement from dependent thinking toward collaborative, system-based perspectives. Here, peer advisors see their role as not the expert who solves problems, but as a facilitator of student sense-making and helping students develop their own capacity to navigate academic systems.

Figure 2.1. A grounded theory of leadership identity development (Komives et al., 2005).



This intervention supports that developmental shift by emphasizing facilitation, interpretation, and shared understanding in advising conversations. Rather than positioning peer advisors as authority figures who provide answers, the program trains them to guide students through complex decision-making processes, surface hidden curriculum, and transfer ownership of academic planning and navigation to the students themselves.

Program Format & Justification

This intervention is designed as a leadership learning series of four workshops in order to support progressive skill development. The four-session format allows Peer Advisors to build from diagnosing student needs, to recognizing hidden curriculum gaps, to translating institutional knowledge, and finally to guiding students toward actionable next steps. Delivering the program over a single week maintains continuity while allowing sufficient time for practice, reflection, and skill reinforcement.

Program Schedule & Timeline

The program is a four-session series delivered over one week (Monday through Thursday) during Peer Advisor training. Each workshop lasts approximately two hours, for a total of eight hours of leadership training. Sessions are sequenced intentionally to support progressive leadership development.

Day	Workshop Title	Duration
Monday	Diagnosing Student Needs (Technical vs. Adaptive)	2 hours
Tuesday	Surfacing the Hidden Curriculum	2 hours
Wednesday	Translation & Sense-Making Skills	2 hours
Thursday	Closing the Loop (Next Steps & Ownership)	2 hours

Pedagogical Approach & Justification

This program uses pedagogies that emphasize active learning, metacognition, and collaborative sense-making. Learning strategies include scenario-based role-play, small-group discussion, structured reflection, and peer feedback. These strategies emphasize learning through action, reflection, and interpretation rather than content delivery alone. Peer advisors need opportunities to practice diagnostic thinking, learn how to facilitate rather than direct, and reflect on their own assumptions about authority and helping.

Scenario-based role-play provides the opportunity to practice responding to realistic advising situations that require judgment and adaptation. Role-play also allows participants to experience multiple perspectives (advisor, student, observer), which supports the LID transition from individual authority to process-oriented facilitation.

Structured reflection activities support metacognitive awareness of decision-making processes. Reflection helps participants examine their instinctive responses and identify patterns in their facilitation practice, stepping back to gain perspective on personal behavior and assumptions.

Small-group discussion and peer feedback promote collaborative sense-making and create a holding environment where participants can surface challenges, examine competing values, and build shared understanding. Peer feedback specifically supports the shift from seeing oneself as an authority with answers to recognizing leadership as a shared, process-oriented activity.

Progressive pedagogical design scaffolds learning across the four workshops. Each session builds on previous skills while increasing complexity: from diagnosing needs (recognizing the problem type) to surfacing hidden curriculum (recognizing what's unstated) to translating information (practicing facilitation) to guiding next steps (transferring ownership). This progression mirrors both the technical-to-adaptive continuum in Adaptive Leadership and the developmental movement from authority-based to process-based leadership in LID.

Integration & Connection

This intervention aligns theoretical frameworks, learning outcomes, program format, and pedagogical strategies. Adaptive Leadership informs the focus on diagnosing student needs and navigating ambiguity, while Leadership Identity Development supports the emphasis on facilitation over authority. The multi-session format allows skills to build progressively, and practice-based pedagogies support observable leadership behaviors aligned with learning outcomes.

The theoretical frameworks directly inform each learning outcome:

Adaptive Leadership's distinction between technical and adaptive challenges shapes Learning Outcome 1, enabling Peer Advisors to diagnose the type of support students need. This framework's emphasis on helping others navigate complexity without providing ready-made solutions underpins Learning Outcomes 2 and 3, which focus on translation and sense-making rather than information delivery.

Leadership Identity Development's process-oriented approach supports Learning Outcomes 4 and 5 by positioning Peer Advisors as facilitators who guide students toward understanding and ownership rather than acting as authority figures who simply provide answers.

The four-session format creates structured progression that mirrors both theoretical frameworks. Each workshop builds on the previous one; and the practice-based pedagogies align with both frameworks' emphasis on learning through experience and reflection. Scenario-based role-play allows Peer Advisors to practice adaptive responses in realistic contexts, while structured reflection and peer feedback support the developmental shifts central to Leadership Identity Development.

References

College of William & Mary. (n.d.). Peer advising. https://www.wm.edu/as/advising/advising/peer_advising/

Dugan, J. P. (2017). *Leadership theory: Cultivating critical perspectives (2nd ed.).* Jossey-Bass.

Guthrie, K. L., & Jenkins, D. M. (2018). *The role of leadership educators: Transforming learning.* Emerald Publishing.

Priest, K. L., Kliewer, B. W., Hornung, M., & Youngblood, R. J. (2018). The role of mentoring, coaching, and advising in developing leadership identity. *New Directions for Student Leadership, 2018*(158), 23–35. https://doi.org/10.1002/yd.20285

Appendix A: Sample Lesson Plans

Workshop 1: Diagnosing Student Needs (Technical vs. Adaptive)

Objective: Peer Advisors will distinguish between technical questions that require information and adaptive challenges that require student sense-making, and identify appropriate response strategies for each type.

Materials Needed:

- Student quote worksheets
- Classification reference guides
- Scenario handouts

☼ Activity Sequence ☼

Welcome & Icebreaker (10 min)

Participants share in pairs: "What's a student question that stumped you or made you unsure how to respond?"

Initial Instinct Check (15 min):

Participants write down their instinctive responses to a series of student questions or quotes, such as "I don't know what classes to take," "I'm confused about registration, or "How do I become a biology major?"

Introduction & Framework (15 min):

Facilitator introduces Adaptive Leadership's distinction between technical problems (clear solutions, information-based) and adaptive challenges (require learning, no one clear answer). Participants look back at their instinct responses and identify: "Which of these were fix-it responses? When does that work and when does it shut down learning?"

Guided Practice with Discussion (15 min)

Facilitator presents 2-3 sample student scenarios. Participants discuss as whole group whether each is technical or adaptive, identifying key indicators, before determining what responses are helpful and what responses are not helpful.

Example scenario

"I'm really confused in my bio class, but I don't know what to ask the professor."

× Not helpful (technical response): "You should go to office hours! They're held on Tuesdays and Thursdays at 2-4pm."

✓ Actually helpful (adaptive facilitation): "Ok, let's think through what is confusing. Is it the lecture content? The textbook? The problem sets? Let's figure out where you're getting stuck, so you can go to office hours with a starting point, even if it's just 'I got lost at **this** concept'..."

Break (15 min)

Small-Group Case Analysis (20 min)

Groups of four participants each receive 10-12 additional student scenarios. Groups categorize each as technical or adaptive, document reasoning, and note patterns they observe.

Whole Group Discussion (20 min)

Discuss cases where categorization was unclear or debated. Facilitator helps identify what makes some situations ambiguous and how to navigate that uncertainty.

Individual Reflection & Transfer (10 min)

Participants write: "What diagnostic questions will you ask yourself in real advising moments?" and share one takeaway with the group.

Workshop 2: Surfacing the Hidden Curriculum

Objective: Peer Advisors will identify implicit academic expectations that may be unfamiliar to incoming students and practice making these expectations explicit in advising conversations.

Materials Needed:

- Scenario handouts with hidden curriculum gaps
- Chart paper for brainstorming
- Advising cards for commonly overlooked assumptions

☼ Activity Sequence ☼

Icebreaker (10 min)

Reflection: "Things I Learned Too Late" (15 min)

Individual written reflection (5 min): "What are some things about college you wish someone had told you explicitly as a first-year?"

Then share in small groups (10 min).

Define & Brainstorm Hidden Curriculum (15 min)

Facilitator introduces the concept of hidden curriculum: unwritten rules and implicit expectations in academic settings. As whole group, brainstorm

examples across categories: advising norms, registration processes, office hours etiquette, academic jargon. Facilitator records on chart.

Practice #1: Scenario Analysis (15 min)

Pairs of participants receive 3-4 written scenarios where hidden curriculum creates barriers. For each: "What is the unstated expectation here?" Pairs identify the implicit rule and rewrite the advisor's response to surface it explicitly.

Break (15 min)

Practice #2: Role-Play (20 min)

In pairs, advisors practice explaining implicit norms (office hours, emailing professors, syllabus navigation) without shaming or overwhelming the student. Switch roles halfway. Focus on tone and framing.

Critical Reflection (20 min)

Whole group discussion: "Who is most harmed when hidden curriculum stays hidden? How does surfacing it connect to equity and access?" Facilitator guides conversation about first-gen students, transfers, international students.

Individual Reflection & Transfer (10 min)

Write: "Which hidden curriculum elements do I assume students know? How can I check assumptions in advising conversations?"

Workshop 3: Translation & Sense-Making Skills

Objective: Peer Advisors will practice translating complex institutional information into accessible guidance that supports student understanding rather than information overload.

Materials Needed:

- Advising scenario cards
- Observer feedback checklists
- Reflection prompts

☼ Activity Sequence ☼

Icebreaker (10 min)

Participants share: "Think of a time you explained something complicated to someone. What made it hard?"

Introduction, Framing & Learning Goals (10 min)

Facilitator introduces the distinction between information delivery and student understanding, emphasizing leadership as facilitation rather than explanation.

Contrast Examples (10 min)

Facilitator presents different responses to the same student questions (one info-heavy, one exploratory). Participants discuss differences and what makes the second answer more effective.

Practice: Role-Play (30 min)

Groups of three participants each rotate roles (Peer Advisor, Student, Observer) to practice advising scenarios while observer provides feedback using checklist focused on clarity, questioning, and pacing.

Break (15 min)

Reflection & Discussion (30 min)

Individually (10 min), participants write about a challenging advising moment from practice: What would you do differently? What questions would help you facilitate rather than info-dump?

Discuss reflections with partner (10 min), focusing on strategies that emerged.

Volunteers share insights or strategies with whole group (10 min).

Wrap-Up & Transfer (10 min)

Facilitator summarizes key facilitation strategies. Participants identify one technique to try in next advising conversation.

Workshop 4: Closing the Loop (Next Steps & Ownership)

Objective: Peer Advisors will practice guiding advising conversations toward clear, actionable next steps that transfer decision-making ownership to students.

Materials Needed:

- Advising scenario cards
- Ambiguous ending revision worksheets
- "Next steps" planning guide

☼ Activity Sequence ☼

Icebreaker (10 min)

Think-pair-share: "Describe a time you left an advising session or office hours feeling more confident than when you arrived."

Introduction & Framing (15 min)

Facilitator discusses difference between giving directions vs facilitating student-owned action plans. Introduces concept of transferring ownership.

Examples with Discussion (10 min)

Facilitator models conversation endings: one that over-directs, one that builds student ownership. Participants identify what makes second more effective.

Practice #1: Role-Play (15 min)

Groups of three participants each practice advising scenarios focused on closing conversations. Rotate roles, with observer providing feedback on how well ownership was transferred to student.

Break (15 min)

Practice #2: Scenario Analysis (20 min)

Groups receive written scenarios of advising conversations that ended poorly (student left confused or passive). Groups rewrite endings to transfer ownership effectively.

Reflection & Application (10 min)

Individually (5 min), write: "How do I balance support with student autonomy? What phrases or questions help me transfer ownership?"

Share in pairs (5 min).

Discussion & Wrap-Up (10 min)

Participants share one strategy they will use in upcoming advising sessions.

Facilitator summarizes key principles.

Program Closure (10 min)